manufactured goods and a critical geo-strategic location for Britain to ensure its global presence.

The ancient belief in India's civilizational sphere of influence spreading from the Middle East to South-East Asia and beyond was translated during the British Raj into a strategic reality. The British viewed India as the springboard for the security of the entire region from the Persian Gulf to South-East Asia. As early as 1943 Indian strategists like K.M. Panikkar championed the British world view to argue for India to step in as the security provider for this vast region. India under Nehru, however, was reluctant to be seen as continuing the policies of a colonial power.

Nehru and his successors did not create a large military presence in the Indian Ocean littoral. Yet, even the idealist Nehru was realist enough to understand the importance of this region to India's security and ensuring India's future as a great power. Thus Nehru built close ties with his peers in Egypt and Turkey and reached out to Arab and Persian politicians and intellectuals. Further, Indian leaders sought to build India's stature through groupings like the Non-Aligned Movement and even the United Nations. In recent years, however, with the growth in Indian economic and military power concomitant with the rise of China, there have been demands that India play this role.

The United States and its allies in East Asia like Japan, South Korea and even Australia appear open to the idea of India as a major power in the Indian Ocean. During the days of the British Empire this had meant a military presence and Britannia ruling the seas. India has so far preferred to build on its cultural ties, boost its economic relations and gradually emphasize strategic ties including military exercises. Slowly, the Indian Navy is emerging as a blue-water navy that might play a role beyond just protecting India's territorial waters.

Modern India is cognizant of President Roosevelt's maxim of speaking softly while keeping a large stick. Yet her leaders have demonstrated a